

ESPI European Space Policy Institute Director's Perspective

THREE UNIQUE YEARS AND THE FUTURE

A FIRST MANDATE AS DIRECTOR OF ESPI AND BEYOND

September 2025

As I am starting my second term as Director of ESPI, I would like to offer some perspectives on three truly unique years of space, and on ESPI's achievements with its people at the core, as a symbol of why purpose and passion matter and will carry us further.

STATE OF SPACE

In September 2022, no one could imagine what lay ahead for Europe and Europe in space and how ESPI itself would rise to the challenge of the times. Just a few months earlier, the 2022 Munich Security Conference still focused on the competition with **China** in innovation. MSC was still considered a platform to combat the climate crisis. Only a few days later the world's attention would turn to **Russia**, and the critical role of space in war took centre stage. The 2024 **European Parliament** elections would show how security would replace climate change on the policy agendas, next only to the economy. NASA still was NASA, yet the change of leadership in the **White House** soon would challenge transatlantic relations and space programmes. MSC 2025 would become the ultimate wake-up call for Europe. The European launcher crisis in comparison almost appears insignificant next to these geo-political shifts, yet has dominated the space debate in Europe for years, while **India** landed on the Moon, Starlink was deployed and Starship took flight.

PEOPLE OF ESPI, ADVISORS & MEMBERS

As I took office, I encountered a team of 12 **b**rilliant staff, ready to take on the challenge in these demanding times. This 2022 Generation would lay the foundation for an unprecedented growth in research activities, outreach and policy impact of the institute. An early highlight of this period was ESPI's 20 years anniversary at the Austrian parliament in 2023, and the publication of the ESPI2040 Vision and Agenda, from Green & Sustainability, Security & Defence and Exploration & Science, from Industry, Innovation, Finance & Workforce to Space capabilities & Regulatory matters.

Over the next three years, the team would grow to 32 staff, completed by 6 secondments. The 2025 recruitment campaign resulted in above 1.000 applications, testimony of a completely new dynamic in the space sector. To accommodate this growth and to open doors to the wider community, ESPI moved to its beautiful new premises in Vienna's first district - Schwarzenbergplatz 16.

During that time, it has been a privilege to also develop the **ESPI Advisory Council** further, strengthening the expertise on policy matters, media and defence and increasing the active participation in numerous activities of ESPI, like the elaboration of a European space strategy 2040 and reflections on the industrial space eco-system in Europe.

New management functions for European and International Engagement provided the basis for an unprecedented growth in **ESPI Membership**, from 16 to 24, and a number of bilateral agreements with members, including ESA, Austria, ASI, and partnerships with international stakeholders like KARI & KASS/ South Korea, Aerospace Corporation/US, Spacetide/ Japan. ESPI was invited to the G20 SLEM in India and Brazil and the invitations to the White House, the Cabinet Office of Japan, the Abu Dhabi Space Debate and the Seoul Defense Dialogue remain among the international highlights of that period.

ACHIEVEMENTS

We set out to increase the policy impact of space, to see space integrated with other policy domains of governments, parliamentarian action and strategies such as digital, green, defence and help design policy also in support of business strategies for industries in other sectors as beneficiaries of

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space, like automotive, finance, pharma. Notable work included "Policy Value of Earth Observation" at the Royal Society, our "Brief on the Draghi Report", appearances at the UK House of Lords, the German Foreign Ministry and at MSC, the Politico Competitive Europe Week, and the first ESPI Round Table of Space Commands.

We saw the successful establishment of the ESPI Vienna Space Diplomat (VSD) initiative, a reinforced role of ESPI with the European Interparliamentary Space Conference (EISC), and ESPI stepping up support to EU Presidencies of Belgium, Poland and now Denmark. ESPI established its presence in Brussels, to strengthen its relations with the EU institutions. The new ESPI Centre for Sustainability and Resilience (CSR) was inaugurated and the support to the European Centre for Space Economy and Commerce (ECSECO) was consolidated. Cooperation with Bertelsmann Foundation supported the first ESPI trans-atlantic dialogue on the sidelines of the 2025 Space Symposium. ESPI established the Network of European Space Think Tanks (NEST). The ESPI summer school was established in cooperation with European Forum Alpbach (EFA) and the European University Institute (EUI).

ESPI operated across 7 different global regions, engaged with more than 25 different European countries, issued more than 150 publications, actively contributed to more than 500 events and forums and generated above 1.000.000 unique views on social media with a threefold increase of followers exceeding 20.000 today, 700.000 impressions over the last year alone.

Most prominent publications included the value of space exploration and ESPI's support to the report on Revolution Space by a High-Level group of experts, Europe as a Space Power, Report on European Parliament Elections, Space Venture, Brief on the EU Space Act, Reconvergence of Defence and Space industry and many other.

Major events, aside ESPI's own Autumn Conference included ESPI's first own session as part of the Brussels Space Conference, keynotes at European Space Forum and ESA Security Conference, ESPI's first stand at IAC24 Milan, ESPI's active role at Spacetide and Institute of Geo-Economics (IGO) in Tokyo and several other occasions.



TOWARDS THE FUTURE

Lessons learned from this period include that investment in people and trust pays off, words and their truthfulness are key, independence is crucial for a healthy ecosystem but in short supply, and people recognize the value of the forum for open, critical and yet always constructive and substantiated debate ESPI stands for. Those years also demonstrate how a team can grow beyond itself, with a passion which can be felt and seen, which consistently is the most common remark we received when out there. Yet we see that every team also deserves a life beyond space, and building increased resilience of the organisation is a core objective for the future.

Today the **2025 Generation**, 38 people from 21 nations, with an average age of 32 years old, a perfect gender equilibrium, driven by purpose and a passion for space and Europe, consists of a highly multi-disciplinary team of political scientists, experts in international affairs, business and legal, economists, scientists and engineers. Without any doubt, this Generation will itself step-up and provide the foundations for the next evolution of ESPI towards 2028 and beyond, as we are heading towards ESPI's biggest Autumn Conference yet, hosted at the Vienna City Hall under the Theme of "Europe as a Space Power".

The perfect conclusion of those magic three years is today's announcement of ESPI being granted the status of Quasi-International Organisation by Austria, defining a pivotal moment for the future of the institute. This will further empower ESPI in its efforts to build trust and help construct bridges within Europe and globally, help increase the policy impact of space in all domains of society, for peace, prosperity and the future of our children. In this, I appreciate the trust and reconfirmed increased support from the founders of ESPI and its members for the challenges ahead.

The years ahead will be most demanding. They will require brave leadership. ESPI together with its members, advisors and stakeholders will help realise Europe's increasing ambition in space and shape Europe's role with like-minded partners globally.

The time is now.

Yours sincerely,

Hermann Ludwig Moeller
Director of ESPI

